



A graded conceptualization of taste[☆]

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Taste
Aesthetic experience
Culture and cognition
Latent social functions
Cultural capital

ABSTRACT

Most empirical sociological work on taste has attended to the determinants and consequences of taste while leaving the nature of taste unexamined. Furthermore, despite the advancements of a Bourdieusian conceptualization of taste, the empirical strategies sociologists have employed have encouraged a collective understanding of taste that is inconsistent, sometimes narrowly circumscribed and sometimes overly broad. We argue that a sociological definition of taste centers on three key dimensions. Tastes are (1) aesthetic preferences involving (2) automatic cognitive engagement and (3) serving a latent social function. Further, we develop a framework for organizing social research on taste we term the “graded conceptualization of taste”: the more a disposition reflects these three dimensions of taste, the closer it is to the core of a sociological conceptualization of taste, as opposed to a peripheral taste or non-aesthetic preference. Recognizing the multidimensionality of taste calls for methods that both complement and corroborate one another to yield a holistic understanding and observation of taste.

1. Introduction

There is no shortage of scholarship on taste. It has long been examined across a range of disciplines, including philosophy (Hume, 1965; Kant, 2000), psychology (Kahneman & Snell, 1992; Skov & Nadal, 2020), and economics (Becker, 1996; Cowen, 1989). Within sociology, taste is a central concept across an array of subfields. It is employed to make sense of findings not only in studies of culture, but also stratification, networks, organizations, economic sociology, consumption, and others. In this article, we begin with a review of prior sociological work on taste to take stock of how sociologists understand taste, moving from foundational conceptual work to contemporary empirical work within sociology. With the benefit of this understanding, and by employing theoretical tools within cultural sociology, we then advance an argument for how we think sociologists should understand taste.

The centrality of the concept notwithstanding, a precise and cohesive sociological understanding of taste has been hampered by several trends in past research. First, “taste” has been invoked to represent preferences for an extremely broad range of phenomena. To

[☆] We thank audiences at the 2023 American Sociological Association Annual Meeting, the 2024 British Journal of Sociology Conference, and especially Clayton Childress and Josée Johnston for helpful advice.

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refine our understanding of taste, we must specify the core objects of taste from the peripheral and extraneous objects of taste. Second, the majority of sociological research on taste has bracketed the question of what taste is in order to focus on the questions of the *determinants* of taste and the *consequences* of taste.¹ Third, most research has relied on the Bourdieusian paradigm that blurs taste into other dimensions of embodied cultural capital without seeking to refine and advance a sociological concept of taste itself.² Fourth, as Van der Waal et al. (2024) convincingly show, sociological research on cultural capital has empirically studied declarative cultural capital (Lizardo, 2017) while employing Bourdieusian theory that focuses on non-declarative cultural capital. Insofar as taste is a component of cultural capital, this mismatch raises questions about the validity of findings on declarative cultural capital. For these reasons, our current conceptualization of taste lacks consistency, despite the wealth of studies that demonstrate the importance of taste for understanding myriad social processes and outcomes.

In this paper we build on Bourdieusian theory, insights from Merton (1968), and sociological dual process models to advance a more refined and consistent sociological conception of taste. We argue that a sociological conceptualization of taste must prioritize *aesthetic preferences that are grounded in automatic cognitive processes and that serve latent social functions*. Rather than proposing a binary of taste vs. non-taste, we argue that the more that preferences exhibit these characteristics, the more they are at the core of our conceptualization of taste. In making this argument, we maintain that although tastes are individually held, they are fundamentally social in nature, both dependent on and acting on individuals' social relations. Our reconceptualization of taste centers its felt and relational characteristics in equal measure, so our review of prior empirical work emphasizes how this work provides only partial articulations of taste as a sociological phenomenon. We believe a graded sociological definition of taste effectively organizes and better situates existing contributions on tastes while providing guidance for conducting empirical work and clarifying its theoretical contributions regarding taste's relationship to social identities, social inequality, social differentiation, cultural production and consumption, and group dynamics. Studies of taste's role in these phenomena have severed the idea of aesthetic preferences from the social effects they are associated with. We argue that this separation is artificial and counter-productive. In this way, our argument suggests social researchers think and write about taste as a variable, a feeling, and a relational force at once.

2. Foundational work on taste

Contemporary sociological work on taste builds on foundational work by Thorstein Veblen and Max Weber. Veblen is one of the earliest sociologically oriented theorists of taste. His concept of conspicuous consumption describes the tendency for people to consume (through expenditures of both time and effort) in ways that demonstrate the possession of wealth, as a means for gaining status (Veblen, 1899:69, 71, 75, 85). For Veblen, tastes are implied by the consumption choices people make, so that we can infer tastes for luxury items, services, and activities. Veblen is not explicit about the question of how consciously tastes are experienced, but there are suggestions of both consciously (strategic) experienced tastes and subconsciously experienced tastes through the long-term "cultivation of the aesthetic faculty" (1899:74). For Veblen, the key characteristic of tastes is that they are performed. Performing certain cultural preferences in a particular social context signals status and contributes to the social construction of symbolic boundaries.

Although not tightly focused on the concept of taste, Weber (1946) provided perhaps the most powerful classic sociological perspective on taste in his writing on status groups. In contrast to classes defined primarily by relations to economic production, status groups are primarily identified and stratified "according to the principles of their consumption of goods as represented by special 'styles of life'" (Weber, 1946:193). In his distinction between classes, status groups, and parties, Weber sought to advance a paradigm for understanding the social order, conflict, and social change. The hierarchy of social esteem accorded to different status groups was a central feature of this paradigm. Crucially, he discussed the styles of life exclusively at the group level: "The decisive role of a 'style of life' in status 'honor' means that status groups are the specific bearers of all 'conventions.' In whatever way it may be manifest, all 'stylization' of life either originates in status groups or is at least conserved by them" (1946:191). If we understand stylized consumption to refer to, among other things, taste, a significant contribution of Weber is to propose that taste preferences are essentially a social phenomenon, where tastes originate in status group membership and serve to reproduce a hierarchy of status groups.

Current sociological work on taste mostly works within the Bourdieusian paradigm. Specifying how Bourdieu (1984) conceptualized taste is difficult because he was not consistent in how he described taste. However, it is reasonable to argue that Bourdieu primarily understood taste to be an automatic, internalized disposition of likes and dislikes of a broad range of cultural objects and genres. Two key sentences from *Distinction* support this view. Bourdieu writes,

Taste, the propensity and capacity to appropriate (materially or symbolically) a given class of classified, classifying objects or practices, is the generative formula of life-style, a unitary set of distinctive preferences which express the same expressive intention in the specific logic of each of the symbolic sub-spaces, furniture, clothing, language or bodily hexis (1984:173).

¹ Describing the impetus for his research on abstract art, Halle wrote that it was ...surprising to discover that in fact we know very little about what happens when people look at abstract art. No one has ever asked, in a systematic way, what people who like abstract art see in it, what goes on in their minds when they view it. Sociological surveys have done little more than document that some people like abstract art and others do not. ... Sociologists have scarcely asked why people like (or dislike) abstract art, let alone investigated the experiential process involved (1992:131-2). We argue that this analytic approach is still typical across analyses of tastes for art, music, literature, film, etc.

² Authors in this tradition have generally defined and conceptualized taste as a *subset* of embodied cultural capital (focused on evaluative aesthetic orientations), an *expression* of habitus (but not a synonym for it), and a *form* of personal culture that may exist in both declarative and nondeclarative formats.

Moreover, he also writes, "...taste, a system of classificatory schemes which may only very partially become conscious, although, as one rises in the social hierarchy, life-style is increasingly a matter of what Weber called the 'stylization of life'" (Bourdieu, 1984:174).

There are several important observations to make about Bourdieu's understanding of taste. First, Bourdieu sees taste as primarily subconscious, or automatic, with the potential to become partially conscious.³ Second, Bourdieu, like Weber, sees taste as an organizing disposition behind a more coherent lifestyle. In other words, taste has a reach beyond any single application to a cultural object or genre of cultural production insofar as it relates to a broader approach to aesthetic appreciation. Third, taste is conceptualized, in its essence, as the "appropriation" of the structures of the field, contingent on one's position in it. The nature of taste is that it is a deep-seated disposition that is shaped by social context. In an important analysis of Bourdieu's writing on taste, Lizardo (2014:336) argues that Bourdieu's genetic theory of taste as socially structured is analytically distinct from his functional theory of taste, which outlines taste's role in social reproduction. We agree with this view and will return to this point. For now, the important point to make is that within Bourdieusian theory, taste reflects an actor's position in a social field.⁴ However, it is worth noting that the social effects or consequences of tastes are analytically distinct from the tastes themselves, as they are implications of taste-holding for individuals.

Although we have benefited enormously from these foundational ideas about taste, we see that there remains work to do in clarifying and specifying what taste means. On the one hand, Bourdieu's concepts of field, capital, and habitus have afforded theoretical leverage for explaining social (im)mobility in different social contexts. On the other hand, within contemporary sociological work on taste, the nature of tastes has become less and less clear.⁵ To preview our point in the next section, we have found that different facets of Bourdieu's broader concept of embodied cultural capital, which includes taste in addition to knowledge, participation, and encultured skill, have become muddled in the sociological literature.

3. Operationalizing taste

Empirical sociological research on taste has flourished for the last four decades, inspired by the Bourdieusian paradigm, even if not always faithful to it. Although the relationship between taste and stratification had long been acknowledged, the concept of cultural capital provided a focus for how to study tastes and a renewed impetus for why to study tastes.

Following Bourdieu, a common operationalization of taste has been to prompt respondents to indicate their likes, and sometimes dislikes, for an array of discrete cultural objects or genres (e.g., Bryson, 1996; Goldberg, 2011; Savage & Gayo, 2011). Putting aside the questions that have been raised about measuring taste at the level of genres (Childress et al., 2021), using stated likes and dislikes as indicators of taste has face validity insofar as it prioritizes preference. In casual usage, taste and preference are often synonymous. Although using vernacular terms within sociology has the advantage of accessibility, employing the casual usage of taste within sociological studies has inhibited the development of knowledge about the causes, nature, and consequences of taste.

Perhaps the most well-known vein of research that takes this approach is the study of cultural omnivorousness, established by Peterson and colleagues (Peterson, 1992; Peterson & Simkus, 1992; Peterson & Kern, 1996). Peterson and his colleagues advanced the cultural omnivore concept to explain what they understood as an unprecedented broadening of tastes among members of high-status occupational groups. This, Peterson argued, represented a shift from snobbishness among high status groups toward appreciation of legitimate, popular, niche, and lowbrow cultural genres (Daenekindt & Roose, 2014; Peterson, 1992; Peterson & Simkus, 1992; Peterson & Kern, 1996; Warde, 2011). While advancing his omnivore thesis, he also asserted "the type of music liked best [is] a good proxy for taste more generally" (Peterson, 1992:248), which echoes a claim of Bourdieu's that "...nothing more clearly affirms one's 'class', nothing more infallibly classifies, than tastes in music" (1984:18). Sociologists have often focused on respondents' musical likes, sometimes along with other cultural activities, to understand differences among social groups related not only to class, but also to age, race, gender, education, and other socially meaningful characteristics (Benski, 1989; Savage, 2006; Warde, Wright & Gayo-Cal, 2008).

Consumption and participation have also been used to measure tastes (e.g., Jaeger et al., 2024; Lizardo, 2006; Roose & Stichele, 2010; Sintas & Álvarez, 2002). This measurement strategy has illuminated the distribution of voracious consumption (Sullivan & Katz-Gerro, 2007) within and between social groups and shifts in consumption patterns across generations (DiMaggio & Mukhtar, 2004; DiMaggio & Ostrower, 1990; Fishman & Lizardo, 2013; Katz-Gerro & Jæger, 2013; López-Sintas & Katz-Gerro, 2005; van Eijck & Knulst, 2005; Yuksek, Dumais & Kamo, 2019). Given that stated likes and dislikes can be critiqued as mere *perceptions* or *professions* of

³ Bourdieu's work relies extensively, although not exclusively, on survey measures of likes and dislikes. We discuss below the conceptual difficulties raised by this empirical strategy for studying taste sociologically, a point that motivates recent work by Van der Waal et al. (2024).

⁴ Bourdieu expanded on this conceptualization of taste to explain why people within particular economic strata tend to share aesthetic preferences. In Bourdieu's model, "tastes of luxury" are held by people whose socialization and social circumstances allow for and encourage refinement that can reflect their privilege and social distinction. On the other hand, "tastes of necessity" are held by people whose social circumstances circumscribe what they can consume, and their tastes are a sort of post-hoc rationalization of preferences that they are constrained to anyway. In the end, those who were raised with more economic and cultural resources will tend to have different tastes from those with less, and the way these individuals wield their cultural capital over their lifetime varies with opportunities afforded to convert their cultural resources into economic and symbolic ones. Although we find these concepts extremely insightful and to have significant empirical support, they are curiously distant from the core concept of taste that we will argue for, precisely because they are dispositions that are so wide ranging that they do not represent tastes as we see them. Specifically, they are dispositions that can describe non-aesthetic preferences and approaches to consumption that are not what we mean by taste.

⁵ An exception to the trend of ambiguity is Xiangyu's (2024) effort to theorize taste. Xiangyu offers a pluralist conceptualization of taste as preference, consumption, and valuation. We aim to offer a graded concept of taste with different core features than what Ma identifies.

tastes (Robette & Roueff, 2014), some studies make the case that participation and consumption measures are more valid. However, measures of consumption or participation *indirectly* access the taste of research participants and are most often themselves reports rather than actual observations. Moreover, consumption and participation can reflect many influences in addition to taste (Yaish & Katz-Gerro, 2012).

Some studies have improved on the measurement of taste by using multiple indicators, namely participation, preferences, and/or knowledge (Bennett et al., 2009; Friedman & Kuipers, 2013; Silva, 2006; Warde, Wright & Gayo-Cal, 2008). There are clear benefits to doing so. However, as we argue below, these indicators, whether individually or in combination, imprecisely measure taste and are not based on a clear conceptualization of taste.

We have sympathy for the use of these indicators, particularly because they facilitate empirical examination of general patterns. However, as Van der Waal et al. (2024) argue, these indicators measure declarative expressions of embodied cultural capital (Lizardo, 2017), while habituated schemas of perception and tastes have important non-declarative dimensions that cannot be captured using the conventional method of operationalizing taste. As they note, empirical research on cultural capital (which extends beyond taste *per se* but certainly applies to taste) has focused on declarative cultural capital because those are the indicators that were readily available to researchers (e.g., survey questions about likes and dislikes). Van der Waal et al. (2024) usefully propose strategies of employing implicit association tests to measure non-declarative cultural capital.⁶

Researchers are increasingly recognizing the shortcomings of how we have empirically studied tastes. For example, Airolidi (2021a) advocates for the use of digital trace data (e.g., YouTube recommendations based on co-viewership patterns) to overcome the methodological constraints of closed-ended survey questions about preferences. Similarly, Sivertsen (2025) integrates survey data and the analysis of Facebook user data on cultural interests and consumption patterns. These studies justify their data in part on a critique of the validity of asking consumers to report their tastes. Notably, they both produce findings that contradict predominant findings based on survey data.

While our goal is narrower and more theoretical, it complements the methodological contributions by Airolidi (2021b), Sivertsen (2025), Van der Waal et al. (2024) and others. Crucially, we argue that the empirical study of taste by sociologists has reproduced narrowly circumscribed and fragmentary conceptualizations of taste. This has been especially true for quantitative research on taste. Qualitative research on taste has produced deeper understandings of what taste is (see, e.g., Banks, 2009; Friedman & Kuipers, 2013; Holt, 1998; Halle, 1992), but work in this vein has not coalesced to advance our conceptualization of taste. The recent methodological moves by quantitative researchers to disrupt the dysfunctional relationship between narrow measures of taste must be accompanied by a sharp theoretical move that can inform better quantitative and qualitative sociological studies of taste.

It is useful to elucidate *why* our conceptualization of taste is impoverished when we empirically study it as declarative culture. These empirical approaches necessarily collapse phenomenological experience and aesthetic judgement (cf. Bourdieu, 1990:160). To illustrate that this bad analytical habit can be traced back to Bourdieu's foundational contribution to the empirical analysis of taste, consider a passage in *Distinction* where he relays two stories of people interacting with Russel Lee's photograph "Hands of Old Homesteader, Iowa." He found that respondents at higher levels in France's socio-economic hierarchy expressed appreciation for the photograph's beauty and compared it to works of art (Bourdieu, 1984:45). In contrast, he found manual workers described the photo and the person in it, one of whom said, "I really feel sorry seeing that poor old woman's hands, they're all knotted, you might say" (Bourdieu, 1984:44). While the photograph remains constant, it provokes an aesthetic experience for the high cultural capital participant but not for the low cultural capital participant. Our interpretation is not that the low cultural capital participant is unable to have an aesthetic experience, but that Bourdieu's participant did not have one in this case. As a result, "liking" or "disliking" the photo is understood as a measure of aesthetic preference when in fact it reflects at least in part whether the respondent has had an aesthetic experience, which is a condition for having an aesthetic preference. Studying taste as declarative culture unduly collapses aesthetic experiences and aesthetic preferences as linked but distinct aspects of cultural consumption.

Agglomerating such patterns of reactions among his research population led Bourdieu to distinguish "tastes for luxury" from "tastes for necessity" as radically incompatible aesthetic experiences grounded in the educational history of individuals across socio-economic groups. But these Bourdieusian styles of cultural appreciation, centered on individuals' relationships to cultural objects, are less fundamental to taste than are the diversity of first-order aesthetic experiences. Other scholars have advanced similar critiques of object-centered analyses (Biernacki, 2012:142; Elchardus & Siongers, 2011; Gerber, 2020:395; Holt, 1997:103; Vassenden & Jonvik, 2022); for example, Friedman (2015) explores the diversity of aesthetic experiences in his study of comedy appreciation finding that low cultural capital respondents' aesthetic experiences were grounded in visceral uncontrollable laughter whereas high cultural

⁶ While Van der Waal et al.'s focus is on cultural capital more broadly, their argument applies to tastes insofar as tastes are at the core of cultural capital. Still, there is a significant difference in their argument regarding cultural capital and our argument here. They argue that cultural capital is engrained in automatic cultural scripts due to milieu-specific socialization, and they make no claims about viscosity or authentic aesthetic experience. Despite this distinction, there is an important similarity to our arguments insofar as we see the need to shift away from reliance on the study of declarative culture to include non-declarative culture (Lizardo 2017). We would argue that both the activation of cultural capital preferences via automatic cognition (per Van der Waal et al.) and the visceral experience of aesthetic preferences (our position) are captured by the concept of non-declarative culture.

capital participants' aesthetic experiences involved being moved emotionally by the comedian or challenged intellectually by the comedian. Collapsing aesthetic experience and preferences for objects enabled social analysts to understand how different preferences are socially distributed, but this approach shortchanges the sociological nature of taste and fails to fully consider how *aesthetic experiences* are socially distributed.⁷

In sum, a basic issue in the sociological literature on taste is that the distinction between objects being perceived or consumed versus objects generating aesthetic experience is mostly unknown and unrecognized, especially within studies relying on quantitative data. Mears (2014) has recognized that particular methods each provide only a partial view of taste. In her case study of fashion model casting and scouting, she posits that different methods can work as a lens to offer "complementary" accounts of taste, but she clarifies that she does not offer "a full account of what taste is" (Mears, 2014:293). We agree with Mears regarding the partial view on taste afforded by any method, thus multiple methods are necessary to provide a holistic view of what taste is in a sociological sense. To be clear, we are not arguing that all researchers must always use multiple methods. However, if they do not do so, they should acknowledge how their measures of taste are partial indicators or indicators that assume a specifically circumscribed conceptualization of taste, and our framework helps situate existing research along dimensions and clarifies what each measure captures. Our graded conceptualization of taste is a multidimensional theoretical tool that enables researchers to appropriately describe the limits of their research and to point out what work is still to be done.

Perhaps the most serious problem generated by the operationalization of taste in the literature is the incentivization to continue to work with partial or unidimensional conceptualizations of taste. The indicators prevalent in the literature promote the analysis of the relationships between tastes and their causes and consequences, but at the expense of a deeper understanding of taste itself. To address this issue, we now advance our graded conceptualization of taste.

4. Centering taste on aesthetics

In our view, taste's ambiguity as a sociological concept is likely related to the ambiguity of the meaning of taste in everyday usage. Unlike some well-functioning sociological concepts (e.g., weak ties, isomorphism), taste was not created by sociologists to represent a specific sociological phenomenon. Sociological usage of the concept of taste is mostly an unrefined adoption of the everyday understandings of taste, in all its variations. As illustrated in the previous section, the aesthetic and encultured facets of Bourdieu's concept of cultural capital have gotten muddled in empirical analyses and have made taste a floppy concept in the sociological literature. Here, we advance a narrower, and, we argue, properly sociological conceptualization of taste by outlining the pleasant, autotelic, and emergent facets of aesthetic experience. Building out from this foundation enables us to clarify priorities for social scientists who seek to measure cultural tastes and for sociological theorists to clarify how taste links ephemeral experience to social phenomena.

One significant way that taste varies in its meanings is through the application of the idea of taste to diverse objects. For example, in addition to having taste in music, people can have a taste for an occupation, for the personality of a companion, for policy outcomes, for travel destinations, for drinking water temperatures, etc. These objects of taste are so diverse that the nature of the taste held cannot be conceptualized with any further specificity than having a positive, negative, or neutral orientation. To make any advancement in conceptualizing taste, we must recognize that taste is not processed and experienced similarly across these examples, and it also has distinct sources and consequences.

We propose that when an object is evaluated primarily for instrumental and other non-aesthetic criteria, *preferences* is the best term to employ, and this reflects the most common current usage. When taste is used for these non-aesthetic preferences, nothing is lost by substituting the term preferences (e.g., a preference for social equality or a preference for spending time with introverts). In contrast, taste should be the common term for *preferences for cultural objects that are evaluated primarily for their aesthetic qualities*. Take for example the title of Bourdieu's most famous book, *Distinction: A social critique of the judgment of taste*. To substitute preferences for tastes in that title would lose the specificity of what the book is actually about – not preferences in general, but for aestheticized cultural objects.⁸

Our proposition that taste as a sociological concept should center on preference for aestheticized objects is grounded in three different dimensions of aestheticization.⁹ The first dimension of aestheticization is the presence of pleasure¹⁰ through the perception of beauty. The Kantian theory of aesthetics foregrounds pleasure through the apprehension of form (Lee, 1931) as a determining feature. Relatedly, recognition of the beautiful or the sublime (see Shapshay (2012) on Schopenhauer) can produce a positive, semi-transcendent experience through perception. For our purposes, it is not necessary to parse distinctions between pleasure and

⁷ Benzecry and Collins (2014) provide a concise and compelling argument for why we need to understand tastes not merely as the reception or consumption of culture, nor as aesthetic judgement, but instead as cultural experiences. Their article breaks down the dimensions inherent to cultural experiences. We note that although their analysis of cultural experiences targets a broader phenomenon than taste, it is compatible with the conceptualization of taste that we advance here.

⁸ In focusing on aesthetic preferences, we are not disputing Bourdieu's (1984) challenges to Kantian aestheticism. Bourdieu argues, contra Kant, that aesthetic judgment is not autonomous and disinterested but rather is deeply embedded in social structures. Our focus on taste as specifically aesthetic preferences does not imply a return to Kantian aesthetics.

⁹ Aestheticization is maximized when all three dimensions are strongly present. However, aestheticization does not require that all three dimensions are always foregrounded. As we say below, aestheticization can occur along a spectrum.

¹⁰ We take an expansive view of pleasure to include displeasure or difficulty on a pathway to experiencing pleasure.

enjoyment, or between the sublime and the charming. What is most important is the focus on the perception of beauty that results in pleasure as a core feature of aestheticization. Wohl (2015:302) argues that aesthetic judgment requires perception of sensory experiences together with affective evaluation, using the example of “exclaiming the beauty of a sunset.” Although we agree that aestheticization can be grounded in sensory experience, we would also argue that aestheticization can happen when sensory experience is backgrounded, like with reading a novel. We would concur strongly with the requirement for affective evaluation as the foundation for experience of pleasure or beauty.

A second dimension of aestheticized objects is that their consumption provides an experience that is perceived as autotelic. As Holt (1998) describes in his analysis of patterns of cultural capital in the United States, some consumption experiences are understood by consumers as an end in themselves, and not strategic action. When individuals perceive or consume aestheticized objects, the experience is felt to be self-contained, as the reaction is exclusively oriented toward a direct reaction to the aestheticized object. In other words, aestheticization is fundamentally non-instrumental.¹¹

The third dimension of aestheticization is that it is not an innate property of some objects but is instead the product of an interaction between a person and an object. We cannot *a priori* identify aestheticized objects. Objects are aestheticized when people are open to bringing a lens of aestheticization to their consumption or perception of an object.¹² A lens of aestheticization is an understanding that an object can be perceived according to the first two dimensions described above, as an object whose form can be evaluated for its beauty, as pleasurable, and as an end in itself. Much of the research discussed in Bourdieu’s (1984) *Distinction* explains with whom, how, and when this aestheticization takes place, most often referred to as the “aesthetic disposition” or “pure gaze.”

Significantly, aestheticization can occur in degrees. For example, a car aficionado might aestheticize a car to a high degree seeing beauty in the car’s design and understand their driving and other interactions with the car as an end into itself, while another person might interact with the same car predominantly instrumentally considering a car to be more or less visually striking, but predominantly a means to an end rather than an end unto itself. For each of them, aestheticization occurs along a spectrum. The car aficionado does not lose awareness of the instrumental features of the car despite aestheticizing it. Thus, it is specifically the aestheticization of objects that makes taste a unique form of preference, one that is grounded in autotelic experiences of sublimity and beauty.¹³

5. Taste and automatic cognition

We draw on recent theorizing about cognition and culture to inform our graded conceptualization of taste. Since the 1990s, the sociology of culture has incorporated the culture and cognition perspective to make significant advancements in understanding linkages between socialization, cognition, and behavior (Brett & Miles 2021; DiMaggio 1997; Vaisey 2009). In the next subsection, we consider social functions that can be attributed to automatic cognitive processes and aesthetic experiences. Here, we consider how automatic and deliberate cognition helps us to productively shift attention from causes and consequences of aesthetic experiences to capture taste as it is actually enacted in social life.

One helpful heuristic is Lizardo’s (2017) model of culture. In this model, public culture (e.g., codes, frames, classifications) is “externalized in the form of public symbols, discourses, and institutions” (Lizardo 2017:93). Public culture contrasts with personal culture, which is internalized at the individual level. Personal culture exists in declarative and nondeclarative forms. Declarative culture is the internalized version of public culture; through exposure to symbolically represented ideas, individuals acquire and store knowledge with awareness, which they hold and understand as their own thinking about the world. Declarative personal culture can take the form of values, attitudes, orientations, worldviews and ideologies. In contrast, nondeclarative personal culture can take the form of skills, dispositions, schemata, prototypes, and associations which means nondeclarative facets of personal culture are slowly and stealthily acquired without awareness by individuals through their interactions in the world. Although Lizardo (2017) does not specifically address tastes with his model of culture, we can readily apply his distinctions to help build our conceptualization of taste.

A useful way to think about the distinction between declarative and nondeclarative culture is to imagine a spectrum of awareness.¹⁴ On the far left is total awareness of thoughts and feelings, and on the far right is total unawareness. Declarative culture exists towards the left end of awareness, consciousness, and reflexivity, and nondeclarative culture exists toward the right end of unawareness and subconsciousness. By proposing a distinction between declarative and nondeclarative culture, Lizardo’s model implies a clear boundary between culture that we are aware of and culture that we hold but are nevertheless unaware of. We propose that a spectrum

¹¹ The non-instrumental character of aestheticization does not foreclose the possibility of having a cultural consumption experience that is more instrumental in nature, over and above the autotelic experience. For example, individuals can have a taste for art that is morally challenging or uplifting. However, instrumental or purposeful cultural consumption on its own, in the absence of an autotelic experience, is not aestheticization.

¹² This understanding of aestheticization as an interaction draws inspiration from Griswold, (2013) concept of a cultural object: Notice that the status of the cultural object results from an analytic decision that we make as observers; it is not built into the object itself. If we think of the quilt as a product in a department store’s inventory or something to warm our feet in bed and not in terms of its meaning, the quilt is not a cultural object. But when we consider it in terms of its story—how it expresses women collectively piecing together scraps to produce an object of beauty and utility—the quilt becomes a meaningful cultural object and may be analyzed as such (2013:11-12).

¹³ Although many examples of aestheticization are stereotypically highbrow, we stress that aesthetic evaluation is exercised by individuals from all classes, even though specific aesthetic preferences may tend to vary with volume of cultural and economic capital. The example of the car highlights that aestheticization is practiced across classes, although it tends differ across classes in how it is practiced.

¹⁴ Lizardo (2017) builds into his model a theory of enculturation regarding how declarative and nondeclarative personal cultures are learned and internalized. Although we see intriguing areas for developing our conceptualization of taste to the question of socialization, that topic is beyond the scope of this paper and we therefore are not delving into the topic of cultural learning.

of awareness is a more accurate representation of tastes.

Degrees of awareness more accurately capture people's engagement with culture. It is a common experience to have some level of awareness that is middling, a kind of hazy knowledge or understanding. The same is true for tastes; we are crystal clear about some of our aesthetic preferences, more ambiguously aware of others, and some of our tastes are experienced and felt automatically without reflexivity, seeming to exist within cognitive oblivion and felt as positive and enjoyable experiences. While different tastes can occupy multiple points along this spectrum, it is also the case that specific tastes can bleed across this spectrum. We would expect that most commonly the direction of the change in awareness would be from right to left, so that tastes that are at first experienced automatically and without reflexivity can over time also and simultaneously be consciously recognized and articulated. However, the possibility also exists that tastes can be developed with effort and intention, at first, and eventually cultivated into aesthetic preferences that are experienced with low effort or automaticity.

The key point of our conceptualization of taste is not to emphasize how aesthetic preference begins, but that to emphasize that tastes are best represented by aesthetic preferences that exist within the realm of unawareness and automaticity of cognition to some degree. This argument relies on our view that aesthetic preferences that are grounded in automatic cognition have greater authenticity to them than aesthetic preferences that are experienced only reflexively. At the same time, we acknowledge that tastes can also be experienced via reflexive awareness. Through examining different combinations of automatic and deliberative cognition in the experience of taste, we can specify how core taste is related to yet distinct from peripheral tastes as well as neighboring phenomena of guilty pleasure and ironic consumption.

Consider two different hypothetical people's taste for the music in the opera *La bohème*. The first person is able to describe a preference or liking for the music, perhaps out of an understanding of their social incentives and penalties, but without a visceral and immediate sense of pleasure and enjoyment when listening to the music. The second person is also able to articulate their preference, but in addition experiences that enjoyment viscerally and automatically. The first person can be seen to have a taste that more closely matches a social performance (or strategic display), whereas the second person more clearly has a taste for the music as we are conceptualizing it.

Lizardo's (2017) distinctions between personal and public culture work well for helping to clarify our conceptualization of taste. Taste is personal rather than public culture. The distinction between declarative and nondeclarative culture is also helpful insofar as this distinction highlights the variation in awareness or automaticity of aesthetic experience and cultural taste. Our understanding of taste does not fit neatly into Lizardo's model of personal culture insofar as taste can at times be declarative and at other times be nondeclarative culture. However, if we modify this model to think of culture on a spectrum between declarative and nondeclarative, rather than a dichotomy, then the distinction remains helpful because we argue that tastes more fundamentally exist at the non-declarative end of the spectrum. In terms of the acquisition of taste as nondeclarative culture, we follow Lizardo's description of the social learning process as "slow learning ... after a (relatively) large number of repeated encodings...[and] may be internalized (and later elicited), without explicit symbolic mediation, *directly* via experiential correlations or manipulation of the body" (2017:92, emphasis in original).

One implication of our conceptualization of tastes is that if an aesthetic preference shifts from an automatic authentic experience toward being purely a conscious aesthetic strategy, it is less a taste. However, we think that such occasions are not the norm. Becoming aware of one's tastes, and of the social implications of one's tastes, usually does not obviate automatic, sincere enjoyment. In some cases, there is perhaps the possibility for this shift to become greater over time, so that sincere enjoyment ends. In our conceptualization, the natural experience of taste does not refer to innateness but rather to a property of cognition associated with high-speed and low effort. However, there are periods of time when both automatic authentic preference and awareness of that preference overlap. In fact, most of our tastes exist in this overlap most of the time. Similarly, it is possible for tastes to become acquired through effort. This could be the case especially for aesthetic preferences that are typically held after a period of targeted socialization or training, as with "difficult" aesthetics or highbrow genres.¹⁵ At first, an aesthetic preference can be entirely consciously held and strategic. Over time, with enough positive experiences, the aesthetic preference can be naturalized and experienced automatically and as a more fundamental taste.

Relatedly, our argument implies that guilty pleasures and ironic consumption are not at the core of our conceptualization of taste. Irony may be a motivational force for cultural consumption, and ironic consumption can shape one's taste by provoking an aesthetic experience. However, ironic consumption, while authentically and sincerely enjoyable, and while capable of helping to accomplish latent social functions, is not an instance of automatic cognition because irony is a mental exercise that requires awareness and thoughtfulness. At their core, tastes are aesthetic preferences that are based on and invoke visceral reactions that require a person to be fully "in the moment." In contrast, ironic consumption invokes meta-feelings related to awareness of social context and cultural field dynamics.¹⁶

Because we draw on the literature on culture and cognition to clarify the nature of tastes, it is helpful to distinguish taste from related concepts that are frequently employed in the literature. Here we draw distinctions between the concepts of *habitual action* and *disposition*. We do not conceptualize taste as habitual action, as that term is employed in sociology, specifically cultural sociology or in practice theory. Our conceptualization of taste centers on nonreflective and subconscious cognition, as with habitual action, while actions, are defined by the decisions a person takes, however subconsciously, to undertake a *behavior*. In contrast, tastes do not require

¹⁵ It is also possible for targeted socialization to happen in traditionally lowbrow genres, such as hip hop music, cartoon culture, or video gaming. We suggest that such targeted socialization is more likely when people consume cultural objects after socialization into the primary habitus.

¹⁶ See Pugh (2013) for a helpful distinction of visceral, honorable, schematic, and meta-feeling information available in interview data.

behavior, even if tastes can drive behavior. Tastes are often operationalized in sociological research through behaviors, such as through consumption choices, as discussed above. However, this is a clear example of slippage between the observed indicator and the underlying concept of interest.

The development over the last several decades of a sociological literature on dual process models has provided us with a helpful set of tools to use to clarify the nature of taste. Bourdieusian theory has provided an important foundation to build from, and we do not see any fundamental tension between our conceptualization of taste and how Bourdieu viewed tastes. Nonetheless, Bourdieu was somewhat vague regarding the relationship between the nature of the habitus and intentional actions when it came to tastes, which resulted in taste not being fully theorized. Our goal in this section has been to employ the more recent insights on culture and cognition to clarify and advance taste beyond the conventional Bourdieusian use of it.

6. Taste serves latent social functions

Tastes are embedded in social processes insofar as they are aesthetic preferences that serve latent social functions.¹⁷ In explaining this point, we emphasize that there is an analogy with automatic and deliberative cognition, insofar as tastes can accomplish both latent and manifest social functions. Just as automatic cognition is outside of conscious awareness, so are latent social functions. Conversely, deliberative cognition and manifest functions are within conscious awareness. Just as we argued that automatic cognition is a fundamental dimension of taste, we argue that latent social functions are another fundamental component of taste. Taste can also have manifest social functions, but it is the accomplishment of latent social functions that is at the core of what makes an aesthetic preference a taste in a sociological sense.¹⁸

Merton (1968) promoted the concepts of manifest and latent functions in sociology. Although not immune to critique (see, e.g., Campbell 1982), these concepts have been foundational for decades. The distinction between manifest and latent social functions was developed to understand the establishment and persistence of social phenomena. Many routine behaviors are explicitly understood by actors as serving a purpose, especially from the individual perspective of the actors themselves. However, these same behaviors can be analyzed from a distance not in terms of how they are understood by the actors themselves, but instead in terms of how the behavior can contribute to patterned social outcomes that the actors might not be aware of. The former are manifest social functions while the latter are latent social functions. There are countless examples of these respective functions. For example, an engagement ring has the manifest social function of symbolizing an agreement between a couple to marry. The engagement ring also has the latent social functions of reaffirming normative gender roles and signaling socioeconomic status. The public education system has the manifest function of imparting a curriculum, while it also has the latent function of enculturating students to routines, schedules, and status differences that they will encounter later in the labor force.

We argue that the conceptualization of taste as aesthetic preferences that serve latent social functions is supported by prior theoretical and empirical sociological literature on taste. Take the work of Bourdieu, for example. An axiom of Bourdieusian field theory is the relationship between the structure of the field and the habitus of the individuals in the field. Through socialization, the ideas and priorities of the field are internalized and naturalized in the individual and form their habitus. As the habitus directs thoughts and actions, the field is then reconstituted by the people who occupy it. Tastes, as derived from the habitus, serve the latent social function of field reproduction. In more concrete terms, Bourdieu draws on Weber (1946:191) to argue that tastes have the manifest social function of facilitating routine cultural consumption and lifestyle choices, while they have the latent social function of legitimating and reproducing social stratification. We can also point to the concept of cultural capital to illustrate manifest and latent social functions. In the context of education, children's cultural capital has the manifest social function of providing educational knowledge and skills and the latent social function of legitimating and reproducing inequality across families of different class backgrounds. Field theory is not "functionalist," but at the same time it is also dependent on, and exemplary of, the duality of manifest and latent social functions.

In our review of empirical sociological work on taste, we find that tastes are consistently argued to serve latent social functions. In Lamont's (1992) work, cultural consumption preferences serve the latent social function of maintaining symbolic boundaries. In the literature on omnivorousness (Peterson & Kern 1996; Rossman & Peterson 2015), eclectic tastes among higher status people signal high status, implicitly reinforce classed boundaries, and shape trajectories of social mobility. Latent identity work of many kinds, in addition to class, is accomplished through tastes. In a study of the nature of cultural capital among privileged younger people, Prieur, Savage, and Flemmen (2023:371) find that tastes among youth "are more dependent on symbolic mastery and less on raw purchase power" and have the latent social function of challenging the status of older generations who have more economic wealth. Carter's (2003) analysis of African-American youths' tastes, which include "non-dominant" aesthetics, can have the latent social function of allowing them to maintain cultural authenticity while also competently interacting with institutional authorities, within a broader

¹⁷ We understand the accomplishment of latent social functions via a field perspective, rather than as a causal relationship between distinct variables. From a field perspective, tastes and latent social functions exist dialectically and are produced via a "double and obscure relation" (Wacquant 1989: 44). The same understanding of the long-term, iterative and reciprocal relationship between the field structure and the habitus is appropriate for understanding the relationship between tastes and their latent social functions.

¹⁸ The term "function" can imply a functionalist perspective. However, there is no requirement to adopt the functionalism paradigm wholesale when employing these concepts, and this has not been the case in common usage regarding latent and manifest social functions. Instead, we can understand latent and manifest functions from a field perspective that emphasizes the co-constitution of subjective dispositions and objective structures, as noted earlier.

social context of racial hierarchy.

In making the case for tastes as serving latent social functions, we are not making an entirely new observation. Indeed, the importance of latent social functions was acknowledged by Veblen, even if he used other terms. Merton recognized this dimension of Veblen's theory of conspicuous consumption, as he discussed the following quotations from *The Theory of the Leisure Class*:

... as sociologists we must go on to consider the latent functions of acquisition, accumulation and consumption, and these latent functions are remote indeed from the manifest functions. "But, it is only when taken in a sense far removed from its naive meaning [i.e. manifest function] that the consumption of goods can be said to afford the incentive from which accumulation invariably proceeds." And among these latent functions, which help explain the persistence and the social location of the pattern of conspicuous consumption, is its symbolization of "pecuniary strength and so of gaining or retaining a good name." The exercise of "punctilious discrimination" in the excellence of "food, drink, shelter, service, ornaments, apparel, amusements" results not merely in direct gratifications derived from the consumption of "superior" to "inferior" articles, but also, and Veblen argues, more importantly, it results in a *heightening or reaffirmation of social status*. (Merton 1968:112)

Through the labels of manifest and latent social functions, Merton illuminated the analytical mode Veblen employed to understand taste sociologically. It seems clear that this mode of analysis is prevalent in sociological research, and especially so in the case of the sociological study of taste. Our contribution here is to make explicit what appears to be tacit knowledge in the field.

When aesthetic preferences work to serve latent social functions, those preferences can be understood more fundamentally as tastes in a sociological sense. To support this assertion, we describe a thought experiment where we imagine the case of a preference for the color pink. In many contemporary Western societies, a preference for pink is laden with meanings that are culturally inflected, because pink is symbolic.¹⁹ However, if we imagine we could divorce the color pink from all its symbolism, such that it is merely a visible color, a preference for that color would be an aesthetic preference, but one that does not accomplish any social functions.²⁰ In the absence of culturally shaped understandings of what pink means, liking or preferring it is a purely personal matter without social relevance. It is more a preference than a taste.

If we change the scenario and think of a preference for pink in the real world, with its existing cultural meanings, the preference for pink becomes a social act that contributes to reproduction of gendered norms of the presentation of self or market segmentation, to name two fairly intuitive examples. We can easily see how a preference for pink can serve latent social functions, as well as manifest social functions, even if the specific social functions can change over time, across people, and across social contexts. The latent social function of the preference for pink exists most clearly in the aggregate reproduction of gender coding and symbolic gender boundaries, which is to say that individual tastes contribute to the social reproduction of gender. Individuals tend not to express their tastes with thoughts of societal-wide implications. For this reason, a taste for pink can have somewhat ambiguous social consequences. The ambiguities and complexities around the symbolism of pink might be cognitively managed through automatic cognition; instead of a discursive consideration of the cultural meanings of pink, an automatic evaluation and response to pink is cognitively efficient and experienced as authentic and spontaneous. Crucially, this experience does not rule out some degree of awareness of the holding of this taste or of the symbolism that it expresses. Tastes can exist as dispositions even when they are not overtly enacted; however, they become sociologically consequential and are closest to the core of the concept of taste when they are expressed or enacted—in choices, talk, reactions, and other forms of social presentation. Through this taste, people are contributing to a latent social function they are not fully aware of, and perhaps also manifest social functions that they are aware of.

Because the meaning of pink in contemporary Western culture is culturally prescribed, there is potential for a conscious, and even socially strategic, preference for pink among adults. We argue that in the absence of any amount of automatic, unself-aware preference for pink – which is to say a purely performative and strategic orientation toward pink – the concept of taste is less applicable. Such a preference might better be understood as an aesthetic strategy. Aesthetic strategies require conscious agency, and they are crafted to accomplish manifest social functions.

Another thought experiment can help to illustrate how latent social functions are at the heart of a sociological conceptualization of taste. Imagine that a person is stranded alone on a desert island. That person will have brought with them all their aesthetic preferences, for example for modern furniture and authentic Mexican food. Clearly these preferences do not disappear upon reaching the desert island. However, in the absence of a social context to give these preferences social consequences, they are not able to fully function sociologically as tastes. Now imagine that this person grew up on this island in total isolation from humans. This person could have aesthetic preferences, but it would be hard to understand these preferences as tastes in a sociological sense, for they would have never had any latent social functions at all.

In making our argument about latent social functions as central to taste, we both rely on and extend the Bourdieusian conceptualization of taste. As noted earlier, Bourdieu's definition of taste is that it is the internalized disposition towards aesthetics that is itself an appropriation of the structure of the field. This genetic theory of taste incorporates social antecedents into the very concept of

¹⁹ In Lizardo's (2017) terms, cultural codes for pink are public culture. They are separate from the taste for pink, which is personal culture. However, personal culture is subject to the influence of public culture.

²⁰ An important contrast can be made between our sociological conceptualization of taste with a psychological conceptualization of taste. The psychological conceptualization of taste could emphasize, for example, the biological or neurological mechanisms that are involved in preferences, which can be studied apart from the social context of cultural consumption and of holding the taste. To be clear, we are not arguing that prior sociological work on taste has been insufficiently sociological. Rather, we acknowledge that our own conceptualization of taste is sociologically oriented and will likely not be useful for work in disciplines such as psychology or philosophy.

taste. We extend this thinking about what taste is to the “other side” of the relationship between taste and society. Taste also inherently *incorporates social consequences*. Indeed, in the absence of social functions, aesthetic preferences lose sociological relevance and are therefore further from what we mean by the term “taste” in sociology.²¹

Table 1 encapsulates our graded model of taste with the rows organized by the core tastes at the top followed by peripheral, borderline, and non-aesthetic preferences; each category further from our core conceptualization of taste. The columns are organized by our three dimensions of taste to describe the relative role of each of the three dimensions in our graded model of taste. The final column presents illustrative examples which are referred to in other parts of the article.

7. Empirical illustrations

To complement our thought experiments and anchor our framework in observed cases, we offer a brief empirical illustration assembled from existing studies of cultural objects. As our conceptualization of taste suggests that it would be best captured by corroborating empirical strategies, we have not identified a single past study that fully illustrates the three dimensions at the core of taste. Instead, we draw out specific dimensions that are present in particular studies to show how multiple methods together provide comprehensive observations of taste. The goal is to demonstrate how elements of our conceptualization of taste have been recognized, and sometimes measured, in past work, but only in piecemeal fashion. By reviewing past work with an eye to synthesizing this work, we illustrate and concretize our conceptualization while also highlighting its research utility.

We begin this illustration with Stanley Lieberman (2000) book *A Matter of Taste: How Names, Fashions, and Culture Change*. Lieberman studies first names because, in addition to signaling gender identity and potentially cultural traditions, they offer a data source on aesthetic preferences, specifically for phonemes, one that is mainly free from market forces such as supply and marketing. People select names based on their liking of names’ aural characteristics and perceived symbolism – their aesthetic qualities. Lieberman leverages large data sets of birth registrations to observe quantitatively patterns of tastes over time and across geographic contexts. Because birth registrations also include information about family context, he can also describe relationships between different socioeconomic variables and tastes. Lieberman’s analysis of name selections produces many fascinating findings about trends in names and comparisons across social and geographic groups. At the same time, Lieberman uses names as a case to talk about tastes and fashion more broadly.

A key observation that Lieberman (2000:2) relies on is that most people “are unable to say what it is that makes something attractive or unattractive to them.” This indicates that tastes for names have an element of non-declarative personal culture. At the same time, tastes are socially patterned. His book is full of incredibly orderly graphs, where names rise and then fall in popularity. On the one hand, people have tastes that they cannot explain. On the other hand, these same tastes are socially coordinated. The patterns that Lieberman observes through adept empirical analysis correspond with dimensions of race, class, gender, cohort, and nationality. For example, although parents might not understand their own name preferences as class-bound, they very often are. In other words, tastes in names serve the latent social function of expressing and reproducing symbolic boundaries. For Lieberman, the social positioning that is implicitly accomplished through the expression of tastes in name selection is an *implication* of those tastes. We are proposing to reframe our understanding of taste so that the social positioning, accomplished through automatic cognition, is not an implication of taste but instead is a constituent *feature* of taste. The automatic cognition and latent social function of symbolic boundary drawing are not downstream elements of taste, they are inherent to the phenomenon that we are studying sociologically as taste.

Although Lieberman’s study makes important suggestions about latent social functions, the data source of birth registrations is not ideal for showing latent social functions. However, we can see a clear example of the latent social function dimension of taste in the example of cultural matching. Rivera (2012) study of cultural matching between job candidates in elite professional service firms and evaluators extends prior work that argues that lifestyle – tastes, cultural knowledge and consumption choices, and self-presentation styles – is consequential for socioeconomic outcomes. Interactions between job applicants and employers demonstrated the role that cultural matching plays in hiring decisions, showing the actual mechanisms through which taste homophily works to affect employment outcomes (Rivera, 2012). Although cultural matching implicates a range of kinds of personal similarities, a central component of cultural matching is similarity based on tastes. Rivera did interviews and conducted participant observation to observe how tastes mattered in interactions and how they influenced consequent social outcomes.

Finally, because of its research design, Lieberman’s work was unable to highlight the visceral, automatic dimension of aesthetic experience that we argue is core to the conceptualization of taste. However, other studies that employ different methods have done so. Friedman’s (2015) study of comedy reception documents multiple aesthetic modes of engagement among audience members with the same routine: visceral, “uncontrollable” laughter; being “moved” by a performer; and reflective appreciation of wit or craft (Friedman 2015). The first two are experienced and reported as immediate and affectively charged. Respondents often describe “bursting” or “being gripped,” classic markers of automatic appraisal and embodied response. These modes are routinely narrativized in post-show talk, where audiences calibrate what *counts* as good comedy and to whom. Moreover, such talk and shared delight carry latent social effects: they create quick affiliation among co-laughers, supply cues for symbolic boundaries (“our kind of humor”), and sort participants across scenes and venues.

Table 2 summarizes how the empirical illustrations align with our conceptualization of tastes. We include here the three main

²¹ In fully embracing a relational sociological perspective on taste, our conceptualization moves away from a causal variable perspective on taste. In field analysis, the elements of the field are understood to be con-constitutive rather than as variables with relationships that are dependent or independent.

Table 1

A graded model of taste for sociological research.

Position in graded model	Aesthetic orientation (high = autotelic engagement)	Cognitive engagement (high = automatic/low-effort component)	Social consequences (high = latent effects when expressed/enacted)	Illustrative example
Core taste (ideal type)	High	High	High	Shared “our kind of humor” comedy appreciation that produces affiliation and boundary work
Peripheral taste: socially muted	High	High	Low	Guilty pleasure enjoyed privately; limited public expression reduces social consequences
Peripheral taste: deliberated/strategic	Low	Low	High	Strategic display of refined preferences without strong in-the-moment pull (cognitive grounding/engagement?)
Aesthetic preference (borderline)	High	Variable	Low	Aesthetic liking with minimal social expression and little patterned consequence
Non-aesthetic preference (outside scope)	Low	Variable	Variable	Instrumental choice (utility-driven) not organized around aesthetic engagement

Table 2

What common empirical approaches most directly observe in the graded model.

Study / Approach	Aesthetic preference	Automatic/low-effort component	Latent social consequences	What it best illustrates
Liebersohn 2000 (Name registrations)	●	○	●	Population-level patterned consequences; weak access to in-situ aesthetic experience
Rivera 2012 (Observation and interviews)	○	●	●	Mechanisms of taste-based matching and stratification; limited access to automatic affect
Friedman, 2015 (Comedy reception)	●	●	○	In-situ affective response + boundary work; closest illustration of “core” conjunction
Airolidi, 2021a,b (Digital traces)	●	○	●	Boundary reproduction via participation traces; aesthetic experience inferred, not directly observed
Van der Waal et al. (IAT and survey)	○	●	○	Nondeclarative associations; aesthetic engagement and social effects require additional measures

studies we discuss in this section as well as more recent work on taste that we review in [Section 3](#).

The graded conceptualization of taste we are proposing is not at odds with these empirical studies of taste. It is, however, conceptually fuller and more precise than the implicit conceptualizations of taste that they work with. These studies provide important empirical and theoretical knowledge about taste. Our conceptualization of taste offers a way for future studies to speak more directly to one another through empirically studying taste more holistically.

8. Conclusion

This article has proposed a graded conceptualization of taste that brings analytical clarity to a term often used inconsistently. We conceptualize taste as comprising (1) aesthetic preferences that are (2) grounded in automatic cognitive processes and that (3) serve latent social functions. At the same time, we have not advocated for a rigid binary of taste and non-taste for future analysts to cling to; such rigidity has, at least in part, gotten us into the definitional and conceptual confusions we have attempted to resolve. Instead, we propose a graded conceptualization that locates the core of taste at the intersection of these three dimensions, with peripheral tastes (but still analyzable as tastes) around this core when one or more of these dimensions are more weakly present.

We were inspired to develop this argument by the vagueness and lack of consistency in the study of taste across many published sociological studies. It is rare for studies to address, even obliquely, the question of what taste is. There is good reason to avoid this question—the answer is complicated. It is also not perceived to be necessary for many studies that are more concerned with the social antecedents and consequences of tastes. Moreover, the limitations of data can push many researchers to adopt imperfect and partial ([Mears, 2014](#)) indicators, which is a problem not constrained to taste. Unfortunately, there can be a cumulative effect of this practice where the indicators can cause a subtle evolution in discipline-level thinking about the nature of the underlying concept. We saw a need to offer a corrective by returning to an interrogation of the concept of taste and providing a conceptual clarification.

Cultural sociology has been strengthened by the culture and cognition paradigm, largely beginning with [DiMaggio's \(1997\)](#) review article, which invigorated the subfield through an articulation of psychological research on automatic and deliberative cognition. This distinction mapped well onto Bourdieusian concepts, especially the habitus, and it was further developed by [Lizardo \(2017\)](#). Consequently, that tastes can have a non-declarative character is well known. However, it remains true that sociological research very often does not integrate this knowledge into the study of tastes. The omnivorousness vein of research is a good example of how tastes are often studied without reference to the spectrum of declarative to non-declarative culture. We offer our refinement of the

conceptualization of taste as a helpful tool to steer studies of taste toward working with this already-accepted spectrum, but we emphasize there are no one-to-one correspondences between methods and dimensions of taste and creative methodological solutions are required if researchers seek to empirically study taste as a multidimensional sociological phenomenon. Regarding the classed nature of tastes, our conceptualization follows a Bourdieusian approach, as well as a social learning approach, where long-term access to aesthetic socialization shapes who can convert mere awareness of a cultural object into experienced taste. Unequal access to aesthetic socialization and to aesthetic encounters is one mechanism through which taste stratifies. It also allows people with more cultural capital to have more aesthetic experiences. People with low cultural capital, of course, have aesthetic experiences. Low cultural capital is not no cultural capital, and there are working-class aesthetics. However, there will be times (like the famous photo of the old hands) when low cultural capital people are less likely to have an aesthetic experience than those with higher cultural capital precisely because they have less cultural capital and are not trained to employ the Bourdieusian pure gaze.

Our conceptualization of taste implies that the study of taste should not only be multimethod but should also embrace methodological innovations. This is particularly evident in the case of methods that attempt to observe non-declarative personal culture, some of which are leveraging the affordances of new media technologies (e.g., Airoldi 2021a; 2021b, 2024). Beyond the embrace of innovation, our refinement of taste also urges sociological scholars of taste to think differently about research design. In proposing that we understand taste as serving latent social functions, we think that studies of taste's consequences would most productively adopt a field analytic perspective rather than a perspective of a causal relationship between distinct variables representing a temporal sequence of cause followed by effect. Envisioning a co-constitutive relationship between subjective tastes and objective social structures is well suited to understanding persistent and ongoing patterns of inequality and domination.

Moving forward with the graded concept of taste we propose, research on taste can be definitionally harmonious, less fragmented, and more definitionally precise and theoretically cohesive. Our conceptualization has several advantages: it disentangles aesthetic experience from mere endorsement or participation with cultural objects; it facilitates the accumulation of knowledge about taste by encouraging researchers to speak more directly to one another and with more focus; and brings forward the full sociological significance of taste through the application of a relational lens that foregrounds taste's connections to social processes, especially stratification. Our goal has been to advance a comprehensive sociological concept of taste that will move the field toward more definitional coherence and rich theoretical syntheses. In summary, future sociological research on taste will benefit if analysts distinguish the aesthetic preferences from instrumental preferences of their research participants, trace the relationship between more declarative versus more nondeclarative forms of aesthetic appreciation, and identify the latent social functions that co-occur with the exercise of aesthetic preferences within a population of sociological interest.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Shyon Baumann: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Conceptualization. **Taylor Price:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Formal analysis, Conceptualization.

Declaration of competing interest

This research received no external financial or non-financial support.
There are no additional relationships to disclose.
There are no patents to disclose.
There are no additional activities to disclose.
We have no conflicts of interest to declare.

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